

SP**20**1998
(4.93)**26**1999
(3.76)**36**2004
(4.32)*Figures in brackets are vote share in per cent***RJD****20**1998
(4.93)**26**1999
(3.76)**24**2004
(2.41)*Figures in brackets are vote share in per cent*

THE REGIONAL PARTIES OCCUPIED THE SPACE AS THE CONGRESS STOCK BEGAN TO FALL IN THE 1980'S.

JD(U)**6**1998
(3.24)**21**1999
(3.1)**12**2004
(3.06)*Figures in brackets are vote share in per cent*

NATIONAL PARTIES HAVE PLAYED SECOND FIDDLE TO DMK AND AIADMK WHICH HAVE SHARED THE SPOILS

DMK**6**1998
(1.44)**12**1999
(1.73)**16**2004
(1.81)*Figures in brackets are vote share in per cent***1990**

WAS WHEN POWERFUL REGIONAL LEADERS ARRIVED AT THE HELM OF NATIONAL PARTIES. THEY WENT ON TO FORM THEIR OWN PARTIES.

sible candidates as early as last September. BJP could declare only 55 candidates so far. That shows the enormity of infighting and allies' pressure. JD(U) wants BJP to concede all Muslim-dominated seats to it. "Kumar thinks that he can do better than the BJP in all Muslim-dominated seats due to the secular credentials that he has established over the years in the state," says a senior BJP leader. The allies, existing and potential, refuse to bow to the supremacy of the Big Brother: it takes three months for RLD chief Ajit Singh to meet Advani; Patnaik wants no photo-op with the BJP mascot; Praja Rajyam founder Chiranjeevi and Telugu Desam Party leader N. Chandrababu Naidu have no time for Advani or anyone else from the BJP—or even friends of the party; the Asom Gana Parishad keeps asking for more seats; AIADMK General Secretary J. Jayalalithaa has already declared Congress is her natural ally; and Trinamool Congress President Mamata Banerjee is no longer in the front. The decline of BJP as a national party is accentuated by the rise of its partners in NDA.

Congress, as the party in power, resembles BJP of 2004: it is steeped in a shining make-believe of immortality. The party leadership is so sure of retaining power that it is at its dictatorial best in dealing with the allies. The Congress version of India Shining is at full throttle. In less than two weeks the UPA Government spent over Rs 300 crore on an advertisement blitz in newspapers and TV channels listing its achievements. And Congress is cherishing its Big Brother moment. It has told the allies that only the Gandhis (Sonia and Rahul) and Prime Minister Manmohan Singh can ensure victory as they alone enjoy popularity. Naturally, the party wants to contest more seats than it did in 2004. The objective is to improve its current tally of 145. It has already asked Lalu and SP chief Mulayam Singh Yadav to give more seats to it in Uttar Pradesh (25) and Bihar (10). It had won nine in Uttar Pradesh and three in Bihar in the last election. In Jharkhand, the party wants to contest eight out of 14 seats. It has none at the moment. The allies refuse to be browbeaten to submission. In Maharashtra, NCP is asking for at